

Date: March 5, 2026

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Office Hours	By appointment only
Classroom:	Always check in Canvas for meeting room usage!
Day and time	Thursdays (1 pm – 4 pm)

MGTP 444: MPAc Capstone

COURSE DESCRIPTION

Accountants build trust and confidence in capital markets all over the world. Accountants are asked to support decision-makers as they navigate the complex demands of a growing number of stakeholders.

Capstone projects are real-world problems and challenges. A faculty member will supervise you and your small team of MPAc peers. You and your colleagues will work side-by-side with business leaders of companies, including small start-ups, government agencies, corporations, or professional services organizations.

Your Capstone Project will be a direct, hands-on experience applying concepts, methodologies, and tools learned in the classroom to actual financial accounting, tax, or consulting issues of the day.

Your Capstone Project will have the charter to work with industry or professional firm sponsors to analyze and address a complex issue facing them or the profession. You and your team will work on combining the knowledge gained through your studies with real-world applications, integrating your experience across functional areas of a business, and delivering findings to your business sponsors or mentors upon project completion.

COURSE OUTCOMES

The Capstone is a hands-on project designed for you to research and communicate complex business, scientific and technical ideas effectively.

You will learn through the Capstone how to effectively communicate complex business, scientific and technical ideas. This will be done by creating a well-written report on a complex business issue or project, presenting your findings and conclusions, and delivering your findings orally in a professional forum or event.

Through this effort, you will:

- Expand your leadership presence and authenticity as a persuasive communicator of complex issues facing business and community leaders.
- Knowledgeably craft and deliver a narrative-driven presentation to inform and likely influence decision-makers.
- Develop communication skills, including gathering the facts, sorting through the rules and regulations to be applied, analyzing, making conclusions, and delivering such advice.

COURSE PARTICIPATION

Success in a Capstone demands that you move considerably beyond your “comfort zone!” All organizations today, especially those that manage through matrix structures, require strong teamwork, especially working with others with different knowledge-based skills and experiences.

Here is a summary of personal and business-related behaviors that will be observed by your faculty sponsor and will be considered in your final grade:

- How willing you are to explore the edges of your comfort zone.
- How ready are you to handle failure in team-based decisions that you are uncomfortable with?
- Will you be open?
- How effectively do you work with and/or integrate perspectives different from your own?
- How well do you help create an environment where everybody is learning and support others’ learning, including on your team project?
- How intellectually rigorous will your topic chosen be?
- How well you respectfully challenge others’ expressed views (including your mentor or instructor) and advocate for your ideas.

GRADING POLICY AND KEY ACTIVITIES

Your final grade will be determined by total performance and engagement through in-class participation, teaming, thoughtfulness, and thoroughness of delivered work on assignments.

Numerous complex and diverse readings and studying will be needed to learn and comprehend the complex topics you have chosen to focus on. Your required assignments are, in reality, milestone events and deliverables outlined below. **Depending on the project you take on – your team’s deliverables may differ considerably from other teams. Your project charter will outline in greater detail those milestone deliverables and times.**

You will be evaluated on your efforts, teaming, and ultimately the deliverables, including presentations to faculty committees. The assessment components are listed below:

Key Milestones and Activities	Focus Team / Individual	Weighting of Grade
Assignment 1 – Introducing your team, team name, and interests	Team	5%
Assignment 2 – Introduction of your Capstone Topic	Team	5%
Assignment 3 – Capstone draft outline and script of topic	Team	5%
Assignment 4 - Draft PowerPoint presentation	Team	5%
Assignment 5 - Walkthrough of presentation	Team	5%
Assignment 6 - LinkedIn Post Assignment (aka Press Release)	Team	5%
Assignment 7 – Team presentations (full-length)	Team	5%
Assignment 8 – Zoom Webinar practice session (full-length)	Team	5%
Assignment 9 – Capstone Presentation (Zoom Webinar)	Team	40%
Assignment 10 – Upload final capstone presentations, outlines, and research into Google Drive	Team	5%
Quiz format – Final reflections	Individual	5%
Classroom Participation – Attendance and Peer Evaluations	Individual	10%

ATTENDANCE

In addition to class time, you will be required to meet with your advisors/mentors/faculty as a team. **Absences will not be tolerated!** You are expected to attend every class and be responsible for the material covered in the course.

However, we realize that despite your best efforts, you might be forced to miss a class due to unforeseen emergencies. Therefore, notification in advance of the session is required. **If you cannot attend a class, please notify your TA in advance!**

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

The integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. Therefore, as Rady School members, we pledge to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and, in so doing, protect the validity of the University's intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned without unauthorized aid.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at <http://senate.ucsd.edu/manual/appendices/appendix2.pdf>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.

Please visit <https://disabilities.ucsd.edu/about/index.html> for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.

ASSIGNMENT DESCRIPTIONS

Assignments will be detailed in Canvas and generally due one day before the scheduled class.

Assignments, both individual and group, received late, without seeking an extension from the instructor in advance, will receive a deduction in grading. The reductions of credits are summarized as follows:

- Assignments submitted late will be reduced by 10%.
- Assignments submitted late – but before the start of class will be reduced by 25%.
- Assignments that are submitted after the class and within three days of the class completion will be reduced by 50%
- Assignments beyond this date will receive no credit

In order for students to participate in class discussions, weekly readings and assignments must be completed before the class for which they are assigned.

COURSE MATERIALS

Required Books

None

Optional: Storytelling & Leadership

The Story Factor. Annette Simmons

Act Like a Leader, Think Like a Leader. Herminia Ibarra The Leadership Engine. Noel Tichy

Creating Signature Stories. David Aaker The Corner Office. Adam Bryant

Optional Presentations

Storytelling with Data. Cole Nussbaumer Knaflic

Data Points: Visualizations That Mean Something. Nathan Yau

Optional Consulting

The Trusted Advisor. Maister, Green & Galford

Managing the Professional Services Firm. David H. Maister

Professional Websites for reference

1. American Accounting Association (www.aaahq.org)
2. American Accounting Association's Auditing Section (www.aaahq.org/audit/index.htm)
3. American Institute of Certified Public Accountants (www.aicpa.org)
4. BDO International (www.bdo.com)
5. California State Board of Accountancy (www.dca.ca.gov/cba)
6. Deloitte (www.deloitte.com)
7. Ernst & Young (www.ey.com)
8. Financial Accounting Standards Board (www.fasb.org)
9. Grant Thornton (www.grantthornton.com)
10. International Auditing and Assurance Standards Board (www.ifac.org/IAASB)
11. International Federation of Accountants (www.ifac.org)
12. Institute of Internal Auditors (www.theiia.org)
13. KPMG (www.kpmg.com)
14. Panel on Audit Effectiveness (www.pobauditpanel.org)
15. PCAOB (www.pcaob.org)
16. PricewaterhouseCoopers (www.pwc.com)
17. Securities and Exchange Commission (www.sec.gov)